Master Website Brief

How to plan, design, build, edit, sell through and prove a professional website: calm editorial clarity, purposeful motion, honest commerce and an editor anyone can use. For any designer, developer or AI.

Starting point: Website Design Research: Editorial clarity, spatial motion, purposeful products (22 October 2026), and Master Website Brief v1.0 (23 October 2026).

Proven on: (1) a 31-page school website and content editor, reviewed by its owner; (2) a one-of-a-kind luxury resale shop with online payment and in-store collection, rebuilt from a custom stack onto the client's existing WordPress hosting, with concurrency-tested stock rules.

Status words: RULE = must follow · DEFAULT = start here, change with a reason · AVOID = tried and rejected · CHECK = verify before launch.

00 / CONTENTS

What is in this brief

01 How to use this brief

02 Decisions: what survived two builds

03 Twelve principles

04 Lessons taught in review

05 Discovery, facts, platform and content

06 Visual system and design direction

07 Page architecture and storytelling

08 Motion system

09 Layout stability

10 The content editor (CMS)

11 Responsive behaviour

12 Accessibility and reduced motion

13 Performance and SEO

14 Security

15 Commerce integrity (new)

16 Hosting, platforms and previews

17 Implementation contract

18 Process, review rounds and agent safety

19 Acceptance checklist

20 Paste-ready prompts for an AI

21 Sources and limits

01 / HOW TO USE THIS BRIEF

Order of authority. (1) The client's words in the current request. (2) The client's brand system, approved facts and existing hosting. (3) This brief. (4) The builder's own taste. When two instructions conflict, name the conflict and ask which wins. Never pick one silently.

Fits: any site that has to explain something real (an organisation, a product range, a shop, a service, a school, a studio) and still feel memorable. **Does not fit:** pure web apps, dashboards or long documentation, which need utility over atmosphere.

Deliver with every build: a responsive implementation; design tokens in one file; a component map; a motion trigger table (effect, trigger, values, fallback); a content editor with drafts, preview, roles and versions; schema or migration steps; an editor guide; a sources register for facts and images; a deployment guide for the client's real hosting; disclosure of anything unfinished, placeholder or unverified; and evidence for every item in chapter 19.

> **Never invent facts.** Names, numbers, prices, dates, results, awards, stock and claims come only from client-supplied sources. Anything awaiting confirmation is labelled in the content and listed in the sources register. Use the client's real photographs. No stock, generated or "example" product images on a live page; test images are plain placeholders marked TEST and never leave the test environment.

What is new in version 2.0

Area	Change
Platform first	Hosting and platform are confirmed in discovery, before architecture. A finished build had to be redone because the client's hosting (cPanel with WordPress) was learned late.
Design direction dial	Two proven directions: *Expressive* (v1 motion system) and *Quiet* (state-only motion, hairlines, square corners). Choose per brand.
AI-pattern avoidance	A named list of looks that read as machine-made, and how to extract principles from references without copying them.
Commerce integrity	New chapter: one-of-a-kind stock, holds, payments, refunds, in-person sales and the tests that prove nothing sells twice.
Security	Own chapter, with platform-level rules (sign-in, uploads, forms, enumeration, output escaping).
Agent safety	Sandbox payments only, no live data changes, no destructive migrations or production deploys without approval, no fabricated results, never handle credentials in chat.
Defaults revised	Inter is no longer a default body face; icons are optional in scanned lists; radius and motion depend on the chosen direction.

02 / DECISIONS

What survived contact with two real builds

The research recommended a combination of clarity, an interaction language and selected signature effects. Build 1 tested them on a school site; build 2 tested the brief itself on a shop. Each idea was kept, changed, dropped or added.

Idea	Earlier proposal	Verdict	What to do now
Spatial explorer (spiral of images)	6–10 images on a shallow helix; wheel and drag; prev/next and list mode.	CHANGED	Keep the helix for Expressive sites. Drive it by page scroll, drag and arrow keys; no visible prev/next buttons. Caption in a fixed two-line slot.
Term spiral	None.	NEW v1	Cards of term + one-line tagline turn as the section pins. For values, principles, features.
Titles stack, separate, exit sideways	Stack → spread → side exit over 1.5–2 viewports.	DROPPED	Too fast and busy. Use a lit statement (Expressive) or a still two-tone statement (Quiet).
Down → across → down chapter	Native scroll pin; x = −D·p; skip link.	KEEP	Measure D against the content box; pin only when D > 0; otherwise a native snap row.
Shared small responses	Text roll, arrow swap, image emphasis, headline reveal.	CHANGED	Expressive: as proposed. Quiet: underline retracts, colour shifts, arrow nudges 3px, second photo crossfades. Nothing re-animates on scroll.
Moving text band	Slow loop with pause.	CHANGED	Expressive only, decorative only, with a pause control. Removed from the shop as "bloat".
Masked / clip reveals	Clip-path reveals for media.	DROPPED	Hid images so lazy loading never fired. Use opacity and scale, or nothing.
Purpose-led storytelling	Outcome → object → name → route → detail → evidence.	KEEP	The backbone of every page (chapter 07). In a shop: piece → facts → status → action.
Palette	Ink, cream canvas, one light accent.	CHANGED	From the client's brand file, by role. One accent reserved for action. Cream only when the brand owns it.
Generous spacing	8px base up to 144.	CHANGED	Section spacing 48–112px. Content-dense pages (shop grid, checkout) use the low end.
Ambient atmosphere	Not specified.	CHANGED	Expressive: faint drifting labels, gentle parallax, sticky asides. Quiet: none; life comes from photographs and live status.
Cards with radius and shadow	Radius 12 for cards; shadows on raised layers.	CHANGED	Hairline structure first. Quiet direction: radius 0, no card shadows. Shadows only on true overlays.
Icon + term + one line	Every scanned list carries an icon.	CHANGED	Icons only where they help recognition. Never icon-in-circle feature grids.
Live status in words	Not specified.	NEW	Anything with state (stock, booking, availability) shows it in words plus a small mark, never colour alone: "On hold until Wed 28 Oct, 4:29pm".
Hosting decided late	"Keep it portable."	DROPPED	Ask what the client already runs before choosing a stack (chapter 05).

Twelve principles

1 **Understand before spectacle.** A calm grid, clear words and real photographs carry the information. Motion adds meaning or atmosphere and is never the only route to content.

2 **Few signatures, well made.** At most one signature scene per page, separated by calm content. A quiet brand may have none; its signature is typography and photography.

3 **Motion lives in the background.** Text stays still once it is read. Motion shows state or adds depth, never decoration for its own sake.

4 **Nothing jumps.** Animated or changing components reserve their space. Swapping a caption, status or counter never moves the page.

5 **Everything visible, everything loaded.** No content depends on a reveal firing. No image is left unloaded because an effect hid it.

6 **Every control goes somewhere.** No dead links and no "page not found" from navigation. Every claim on the page matches what is switched on (for example, "pay online" appears only when online payment is configured).

7 **Less text, better text.** Lead with what the reader needs. Plain, specific words. No fake urgency.

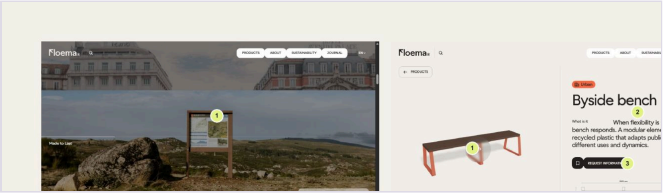
8 **Accessible by construction.** Semantic HTML first; keyboard and screen-reader parity; non-text contrast at least 3:1; a designed reduced-motion version of every scene.

9 **Editors are users too.** Every visual option and business setting is a plain, bounded choice in the editor, with drafts, preview, roles and version history.

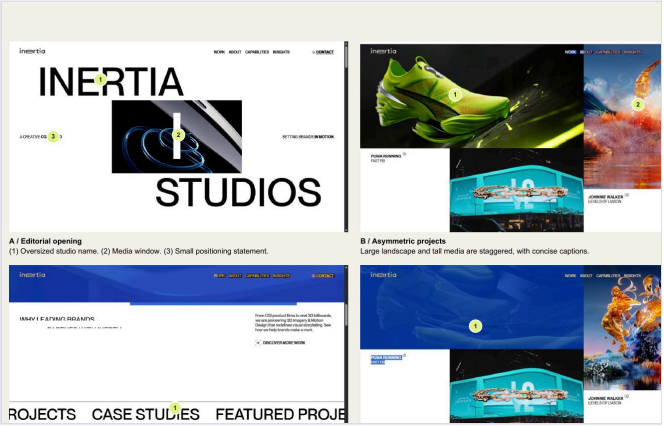
10 **The client's platform wins.** Build on what the client already runs and can maintain, unless they choose otherwise.

11 **Business rules live below the design.** Stock, payments, holds and security belong in a layer that survives a redesign (a plugin or service), not in templates.

12 **Prove it, then show it.** Automated tests, concurrency tests for anything that can be sold or booked, accessibility scans, overflow checks, link and image crawls. Report results honestly, failures and untested items included.



Research reference: purpose-led storytelling. The object in its environment, then name, purpose and action.



Research reference: a shared language of small responses (text roll, arrow swap, image emphasis, moving band).

What site owners taught, as rules

Each row is feedback an owner gave while reviewing a build, why it happened, and the rule that now applies to every project. Rows marked 2.0 come from the shop build.

Owner said	Why it happened	Rule from now on
"Just make the picture interactive."	Visible controls made the signature feel like a widget.	RULE Galleries are driven by scroll and drag, with keyboard arrows when focused. A one-line hint, not buttons.
"The description goes to two lines and shifts the whole page."	Variable-length text inside an animated component.	RULE Captions and counters sit in fixed-height slots on fixed grid rows. Test by cycling every state.
"Use the spiral, less text and icons for each."	Lists were read as paragraphs.	RULE Values and features: term + one line (icon where it helps). Full text stays in the editor.
"The left part is cut off and isn't a real way to scroll."	Overflow measured against the padded box.	RULE Measure against the content box; pin only if it overflows, otherwise a native snap row.
"Too much animation; headings move randomly."	Scroll-linked sideways headings strain the eyes.	AVOID Moving headings with scroll. Headings fade up once at most.
"Some images don't load." / "Lots of empty space."	Clip-path curtains blocked lazy loading; spacing too generous.	AVOID Hiding images fully. RULE Eager-load inside moving scenes; section spacing 48–112px.
"I'm stuck on a full white page."	Page transitions stall in embedded viewers.	AVOID View transitions and page-enter animations unless tested in every viewer the client uses.
"Many buttons just say no page exists."	Script-drawn links pointed to routes the preview lacked.	RULE Crawl every link, including menus and search results.
"The scroll indicator colour is ugly."	A multi-hue gradient turned muddy.	RULE One saturated brand colour.
"There's a collision" (lines across a button).	Focus ring of an invisible jump target.	RULE Programmatic jump targets: zero height, `outline: none`.
"Have down arrows when there's a lot of text."	Long passages needed a cue.	RULE "Read more" over about 1,100 characters.
"I want to actually see the site, not images."	Screenshots don't let people test.	RULE A working preview where the platform allows it; where it can't run in the viewer (a database-backed shop), a clearly labelled screenshot preview plus a staging site.
2.0 "We use cPanel and WordPress."	Hosting was asked as "not decided"; the stack was chosen first.	RULE Ask for the live site, host, control panel, CMS and who maintains it before architecture.
2.0 "No fake stock or gallery images."	Example content reads as a real offer.	RULE Empty states say so honestly ("New pieces are being photographed") and route to contact.
2.0 "No random bloat."	A quiz, music, a brand band and builders had accumulated.	RULE Every feature names the visitor task it serves, or it goes.
2.0 "Make it impossible to sell one piece to two customers."	Stock checks in application code race each other.	RULE Chapter 15: database-enforced holds, locked payment confirmation, tests with parallel buyers.
2.0 "Eliminate AI-generated design patterns."	Defaults cluster on the same looks.	RULE Chapter 06 avoid list; choose type and colour from the brand, not the reflex.
2.0 "Reserve in the cart max 1 day."	Long holds let one visitor block stock.	RULE Hard ceiling in settings, no silent renewal, per-cart and per-visitor caps, shorter guest holds.

Start from what is true

Inputs to request before designing

Brand	Official logo files (SVG), colour values, typefaces and licences, existing guidelines.
Facts	Every claim the site may make, with its source and owner: names, numbers, prices, dates, addresses, contacts, policies.
Platform NEW	The current live site and its CMS; the host and control panel (for example cPanel); available runtimes (PHP, Node, databases); who maintains it; whether access exists. Never ask for passwords in chat; the client keeps credentials.
Commerce NEW	What is sold (one-of-a-kind or quantities); payment providers and accounts; in-person payment and collection; hold and reservation rules; refund and return policy; delivery areas and fees; who handles orders.
Structure	Audiences and their top tasks; pages and navigation labels; legacy URLs to redirect.
Media	Real photographs with release status and alt-text context; documents.
Operations	Roles; where forms go; analytics and consent; email sending (SMTP); cron or scheduled jobs.
Direction	Reference sites and what the client likes in each; visual "don'ts"; the devices and viewers they review on.

Facts register

RULE Keep a sources document listing every fact, where it came from, its owner and status (approved, awaiting confirmation). Content awaiting confirmation is visibly labelled on the page, and staff can clear that label themselves once confirmed. Results and figures carry a year label.

Writing for the site

- Headings describe the content ("How buying works", not "Your journey begins"). Link text makes sense on its own.
- State and time in plain words: "Held for you until Wed 28 Oct, 4:29pm". No countdown pressure, no "only 1 left!" on one-of-a-kind items.
- Dates and times in one human format. Prices in the local currency format the client uses.
- Alternative text describes what is shown and never names private individuals or children.

Questions to ask, and when not to

Ask when the answer changes what gets built: a missing fact, a brand rule, the hosting platform, a payment provider, a conflict between instructions. Don't ask for things with a sensible default; state the default and proceed. When the owner says "your call", choose, explain briefly and keep the choice reversible in the editor.

Tokens by role, filled from the brand

Define tokens once and derive everything from them. Colours are defined by role; the brand fills the roles. Take values from the official logo file, not from screenshots.

Role	Use
Ink / primary	Headings and body text; dark bands.
Accent (action)	Buttons, focus ring, the one brand mark. Reserved for action, never decoration.
Muted text	Secondary text, at least 4.5:1 on every surface it sits on.
Canvas and tint	Page background and alternate bands.
Lines	Decorative hairlines (any contrast) and control borders (at least 3:1).
Status	Held, reserved, error, success: always with words.

RULE Body text at least 4.5:1, large text at least 3:1, input borders and other component boundaries at least 3:1 (WCAG 1.4.11). Compute every pair; write the ratio next to the token. Never convey meaning by colour alone.

Choose a direction

	Expressive	Quiet
Fits	Schools, studios, cultural and product launches; owners who want the site to "feel alive".	Luxury, editorial, retail and services where objects and trust carry the page.
Type	Brand display face 600–700 + neutral sans.	Editorial serif (optical sizes) for headings + quiet humanist or grotesque sans; brand face only for the wordmark.
Shape	Radius 8 small, 12 buttons and cards, 16–20 photographs.	Radius 0; hairlines instead of cards; no card shadows.
Motion	Chapter 08 full system, one signature per page.	State only: underline, colour, a slow second-photo crossfade, menu fade.
Layout	Spiral hero, sideways chapter, lit statement.	Asymmetric splits (5/7, 6/5), a still two-tone statement, ledger rows, 3-up product rails (2-up on phones).
Detail	Background labels, progress line.	Tabular figures for prices and stock numbers; status marks; precise metadata.

Token	Default	Notes
Typefaces	Chosen from the brand and the direction, never by reflex.	Self-hosted woff2, two preloaded at most; open or licensed fonts only.
Type scale	Expressive: Display 40→104px · H1 36→72 · H2 30→56 · H3 20→28. Quiet: Display 42→88 · H1 36→64 · H2 28→42 · H3 22. Both: Lead 18→21 · Body 16–18 (line 1.6) · Meta at least 13.	Fluid `clamp()`; `text-wrap: balance` on headings.
Container	Max 1440px; gutters clamp(20px, 4vw, 56–64px).	Grid tracks `minmax(0, 1fr)`, never bare `1fr` or auto.
Section spacing	48→112px.	Alternate plain and tinted bands.
Buttons	Primary (accent), outline, light (on dark); at least 44px tall, 48 default.	The label states the action.

Avoid list: patterns that read as machine-made

AVOID unless the client asks for it: icon-in-circle feature grids; gradient blobs and purple-to-blue heroes; pill badges everywhere; rounded cards with drop shadows as the only structure; thick coloured left borders on notices; emoji as section markers; everything centred; scroll-triggered fade-ins on every block; Inter or Space Grotesk as the reflex face; "Elevate your…", "Unlock…", "Seamless…" copy; fake urgency, fake reviews, fake stock; numbered 01/02/03 markers on things that are not a sequence.

Learning from references without copying

Study two or three references the client likes. For each, write the principle, not the look: "one accent reserved for action", "structure from hairlines and space", "precise small metadata", "products few per row, as objects". Then express each principle in the client's own brand, words and photographs. Never copy layouts, fonts, code or wording.

Explain, show, prove, act

Home page flow

1. **Promise + hero.** One sentence of outcome, two actions, and the most characteristic real image (Expressive: the spiral gallery and a scroll cue; Quiet: the newest real product, or a brand card when there is none).
2. **Fact strip or statement.** Three or four verified facts, or one two-tone statement built from approved brand lines.
3. **The offer.** Newest pieces, programmes or services, from live data.
4. **How it works.** A real sequence (numbered only because it is one), adapting to what is switched on.
5. **About and evidence.** Stories, results, process, guarantees the client actually makes.
6. **Direct action.** Visit, enquire, buy or contact, with the address.

Shop flows NEW

Shop	Category tabs; a filter form that works without JavaScript (search, designer, condition, order, include recently sold); status on every card; an honest empty state.
Product	Photographs (swipe row on phones with a counter); a sticky panel with price, availability in words, the one action, ask by form or messaging, facts in label/value rows, condition notes, assurances. A phone buy bar appears only after the main button scrolls away.
Cart	Each line shows how long it is held. Removing releases the hold at once.
Checkout	Only fields the chosen fulfilment needs (collection: name, phone, email; delivery: address). Payment options exactly match what is configured. A plain line on who processes payment.
Order received	What happens next, by status (paid, reserved, refund due), with the boutique address for collection.

Interior page template

Hero → introduction → two to five content sections → related links → one call-to-action band. Breadcrumbs below the top level. Each audience reaches its top task within one click of the home page.

Site-wide essentials

Sticky header with a skip link, menus and search; a phone menu as a native dialog; a footer with contacts, policies and a disclaimer where brand names belong to others; a cookie notice only when non-essential cookies exist; a search page that works without JavaScript; a helpful 404; sitemap, robots, metadata and structured data (skipped when an SEO plugin owns them); redirects from legacy URLs; no-index on cart, checkout and account.

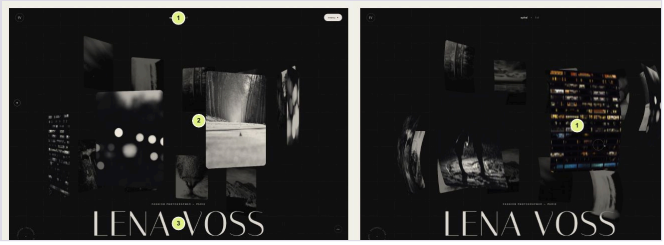
Three levels, one owner, calm by default

Level 1 is feedback (150–300ms). Level 2 is reveals and ambient motion (450–900ms, or tied to scroll). Level 3 is the signature scenes: at most one per page, Expressive direction only. One frame-throttled scroll listener owns every scroll-driven effect. Native scrolling only.

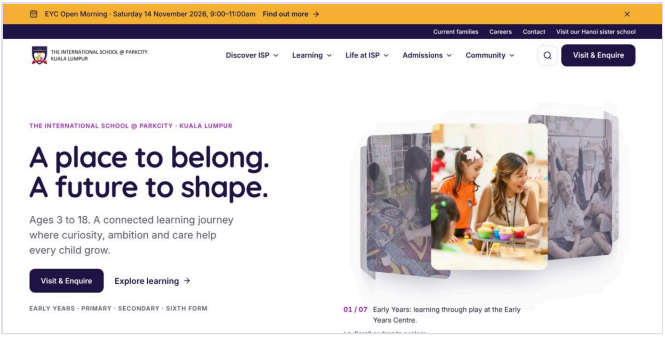
Effect	Trigger	Starting values (proven)	Fallback
Spatial gallery	Page scroll (1 item per ~160px), drag (8px threshold), arrow keys.	6–10 items on a helix: radius 50% of stage, ~36° apart, rise 3%; damping ~90ms; cards 40% wide; tilt ≤2°.	Reduced motion: instant. A semantic list with a live caption.
Term spiral	Section pins; 0.5 viewport heights per card; Skip.	Radius 75% of stage, ~30° apart; damping ~110ms.	Below ~900×640 or reduced motion: snap row.
Sideways chapter	Outer height 100vh + D; x = −D·p.	Cards clamp(280px, 27vw, 400px) from the content edge; progress line, Skip.	D ≤ 0, below 1024×640, or reduced motion: snap row.
Lit statement	Section holds; words light between 10% and 80% of travel.	Travel ~260vh; muted (still ≥4.5:1) → full colour; underline scaleX 0→1.	All lit, not pinned.
Heading reveal	Once, on entry.	Words fade and rise 0.25em, 900ms, 40ms stagger.	Static.
Media reveal	Once, on entry.	Opacity 0→1, scale 1.035→1, 560ms; images stay laid out and loaded.	Immediate.
Photo parallax	While on screen.	±28–48px; image enlarged 12%.	None.
Background label	While on screen.	3.5–10rem, ~4.5% opacity, ±70px, CSS-generated.	Hidden under 768px.
Sticky aside	Native sticky.	Top = header + 24px; aside shorter than the text beside it.	Stacked on mobile.
Read more / scroll cue	Text over ~1,100 characters; under the hero.	Opens at ~26rem with a fade mask; 44px round arrow.	Full text without JavaScript.
Links and buttons	Hover = focus.	Expressive: text roll and arrow swap 220–320ms. Quiet: underline retracts 240ms, colour 160ms, arrow nudges 3px. Easing cubic-bezier(.22,1,.36,1).	Colour and underline.
Product photo swap NEW	Hover on a pointer device.	Second photo crossfades 600ms; first scales to 1.015 over 900ms.	First photo only.
Overlays	Menu, search, viewer.	Native modal dialog; 200–320ms fade; Escape closes; focus returns.	Instant.

Avoid list. Scroll-linked sideways headings; title choreography; clip-path curtains that hide images; reveals that leave content hidden if a script fails; page transitions; multi-hue progress bars; visible gallery control clutter; autoplay without a pause control; custom cursors; WebGL where CSS is enough; any motion on a Quiet site that does not show state.

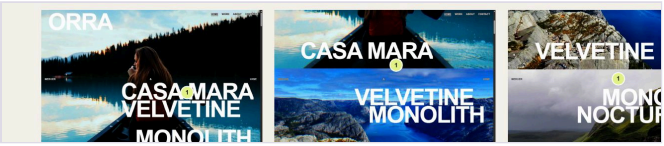
From research reference to built scene



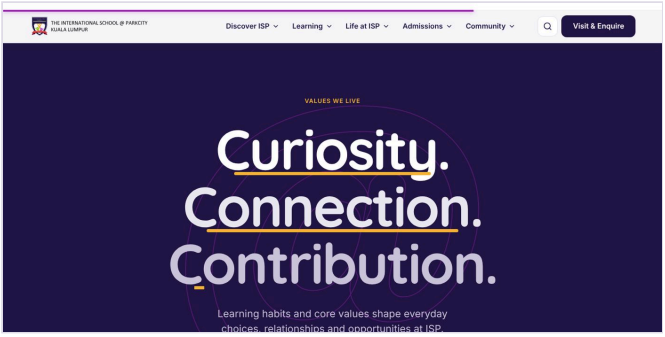
Research: spatial explorer (wheel, drag, depth).



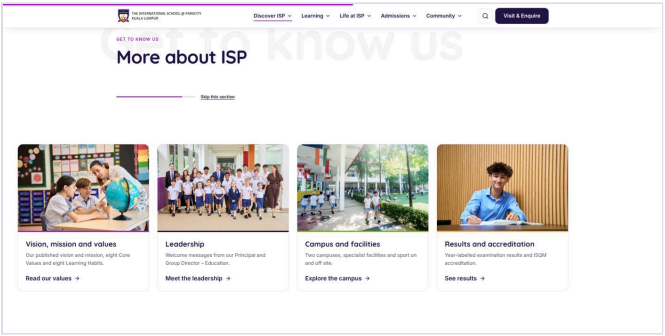
Built: scroll- and drag-driven helix, no visible controls, fixed caption.



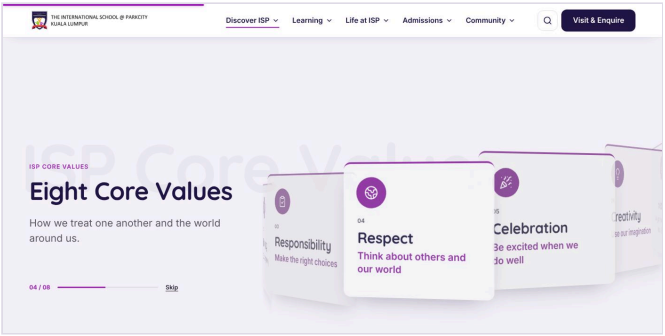
Research: stacked titles exiting sideways. Built, then dropped.



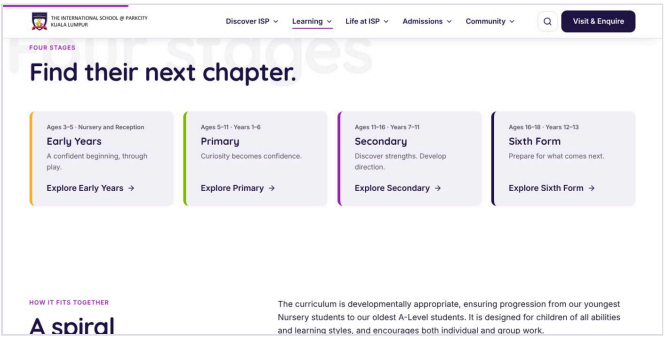
Built replacement: lit statement, words brighten in turn.



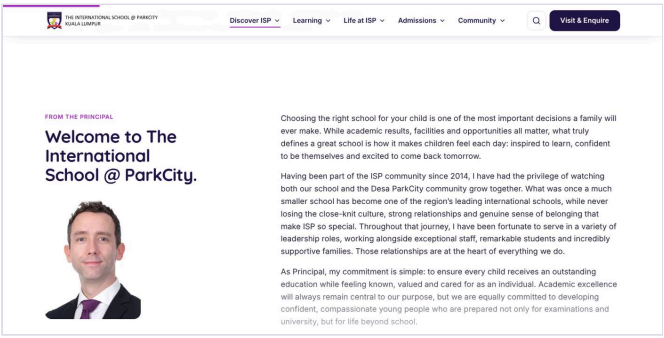
Sideways chapter aligned to the content edge; pins only when it overflows.



Term spiral (term, tagline).



Faint background label drifting behind a still heading.

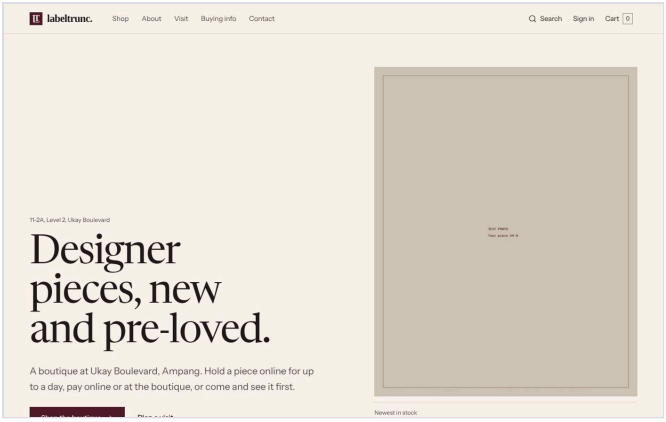


Sticky aside and Read more.

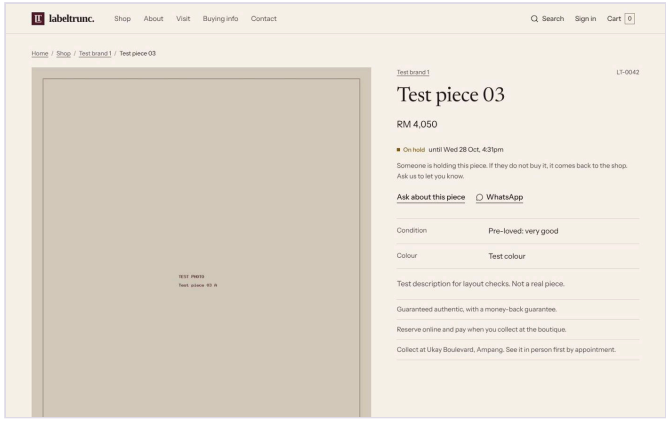
08 / QUIET DIRECTION: BUILT FRAMES NEW

The same rules, with almost no motion

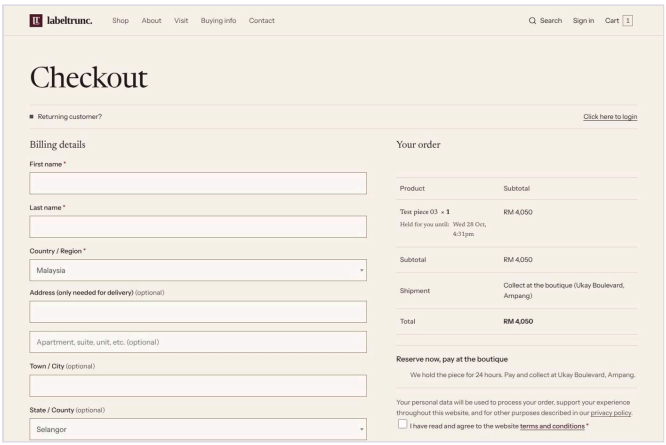
From the shop build. Test pieces and placeholder photos are marked TEST; they never appear on a live site.



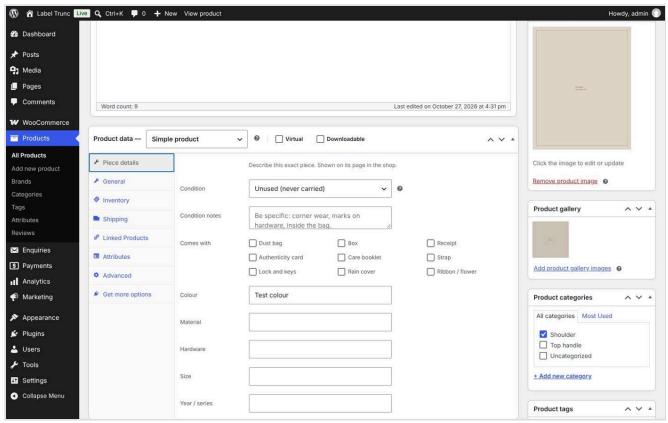
Asymmetric hero: still heading, the newest real piece as the image, captioned with name and price. Hairlines, square corners, one accent for the action.



Live status in words: a second shopper sees "On hold until Wed 28 Oct, 4:29pm", no buy button, and a way to ask.



Checkout asks only what collection needs; payment options match what is configured; the hold time shows in the summary.



Editor: a "Piece details" tab with bounded choices (condition, what it comes with, measurements) instead of free-form text.

09 / LAYOUT STABILITY

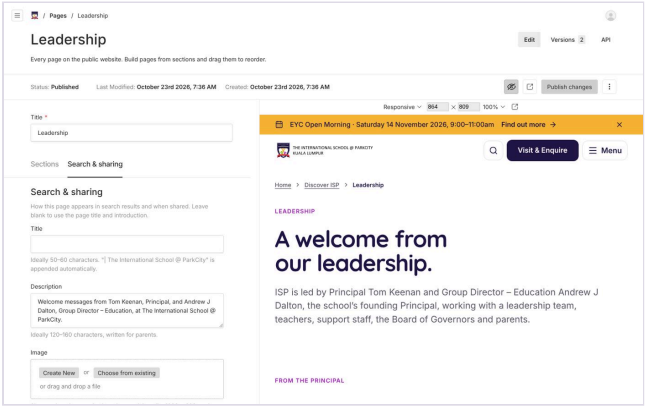
Nothing jumps, nothing is lost

- RULE Variable text in animated or live components sits in fixed slots (height, line clamp, fixed rows). Cycling every state must not move the next section.
- RULE Images declare width and height and sit in aspect-ratio frames (4:5 for products). Media frames are never empty; a missing photo shows a labelled placeholder.
- RULE Grid tracks are `minmax(0, 1fr)` and grid children holding text or images get `min-width: 0`. A bare auto or 1fr track lets an 800px image push the page wide on phones.
- RULE Long unbreakable strings (email addresses, URLs) get `overflow-wrap: anywhere` in narrow columns.
- RULE Pinned scenes compute their length from measured overflow and never pin when there is nothing to move.
- RULE No horizontal page scroll at any width from 320px: clip decorative overflow on `main`; only tables and code scroll inside their own boxes.
- RULE The first hero never animates in, and its main image loads eagerly with high priority.

10 / THE CONTENT EDITOR

Editors are users too

- **Pages:** block-based, with every visual option a labelled choice; drafts, an explicit Publish, version history and restore.
- **Products:** structured fields instead of prose (condition from a fixed list, what it comes with as checkboxes, measurements). Automatic stock numbers. A product cannot be published without a photo, a price and a condition; the editor says exactly what is missing.
- **Business settings:** holds, payment windows, caps and display periods are numbers with enforced minimum and maximum, in the platform's own settings screens.
- **Today view:** one dashboard panel listing what needs a person (refunds due, orders to prepare, reservations, new enquiries) with links.
- **Live status for staff:** an availability column in the product list (available, in a cart, reserved, sold, with order numbers).
- **Shared settings:** contacts, hours, social links, home page text edited once (for WordPress, the Customizer) and never hard-coded in templates.
- **Roles:** map to the platform's roles (for WordPress + WooCommerce: Shop manager for daily work, Administrator for plugins, keys and users).
- **Enquiries:** a private inbox created only by the site's forms, with a status workflow and an email copy.
- **Hand-over:** a plain-English editor guide written against the real screen labels, checked against the code.



Build 1 editor live preview: the form on the left, the real page on the right.

11 / RESPONSIVE

Every width designed, not squeezed

Width	Behaviour (defaults)
≥ ~1360px	Full navigation. Pinned scenes active when they overflow.
1000–1359px	Menu button before any label wraps (find the breakpoint with the longest labels). Product pages keep the two-column gallery and sticky panel.
700–999px	Snap rows instead of pins; three-column product grid; gallery becomes a swipe row.
< 700px	Single column; two-column product grid; phone buy bar with safe-area padding; secondary header items move into the menu.

CHECK 320, 390, 412, 768, 820, 1024, 1366, 1440 and 1920px; long titles; 200% zoom; the client's own device and viewer.

12 / ACCESSIBILITY AND REDUCED MOTION

Same content, every way in

- Honour `prefers-reduced-motion` in CSS and JavaScript: no pinning, parallax, drifting or crossfades.
- Buttons for actions, links for navigation; 44×44px targets; a visible 2–3px focus ring in the action colour (a light colour on dark bands).
- Contrast: text 4.5:1, large text 3:1, input borders and component edges 3:1. Status always has words.
- Native dialogs for menus; skip link; one `main` landmark; breadcrumbs as an ordered list with `aria-current`.
- Forms: real labels, errors linked with `aria-describedby` and `aria-invalid`, the error summary takes focus, answers kept on error, spam controls without CAPTCHAs.
- When the platform's scripts change form labels or rules in the browser (for example address fields by country), fix it in the platform's data, not with a later override.
- Zero serious or critical axe violations (WCAG 2.2 A and AA) on representative pages, including cart and checkout.

13 / PERFORMANCE AND SEO

Fast first, then rich

- Responsive image sizes per component (`sizes` attribute); preload only the first hero image; lazy-load below the fold except inside moving scenes.
- One stylesheet and one deferred script for the theme where possible; remove the platform's default front-end styles you replace; no icon fonts (inline only the SVG icons used).
- Animate transform and opacity only.
- Metadata, Open Graph and structured data from one place, and skipped when the client's SEO plugin is active.
- Cache public pages briefly where they show live status; never cache cart, checkout or account.
- CHECK Lighthouse accessibility, best practices and SEO 100; performance at least 85 on mobile for key pages, measured on the client's real host.

Safe by default, on any platform

Area	Rule
Sign-in	No public staff sign-up. Lock a sign-in after 5 failures for 15 minutes (keyed by a hash, never stored raw). Throttle password resets (5 per hour). Customers may register only where the shop needs accounts.
Enumeration	Hide user lists from public APIs; redirect author-ID lookups; remove generator banners. Disable legacy remote-procedure endpoints (for example XML-RPC) unless a named integration needs them.
Headers	`X-Content-Type-Options: nosniff`, a referrer policy, `frame-ancestors 'self'`, a permissions policy; HSTS only when served over https.
Uploads	Staff below administrator: images and PDF only, real image check, size cap (for example 15 MB).
Forms	Nonce or CSRF token, honeypot, a signed minimum-time stamp, rate limit per address; server-side validation; error state stored under a random token, never keyed by IP (people sharing a connection would see each other's answers).
Output	Escape every value at output for its context (HTML, attribute, URL). Structured data JSON is encoded with tag escaping so no field can close the script.
Data	Private content types (enquiries, orders) are readable only by the roles that handle them. Payment details never touch the site; the provider's hosted pages collect them.
Credentials	Keys live in the platform's settings or server environment. Never paste, request or commit passwords or API keys.

15 / COMMERCE INTEGRITY NEW

Nothing sells twice

For one-of-a-kind stock (resale, art, vintage, bookable slots) every rule below is required. For quantity stock the same rules apply per unit.

Situation	Rule
Two people add the same piece	RULE A hold table with the piece as its primary key; acquiring a hold is one atomic insert-if-absent. The loser re-reads the winner and is told the piece is held, with the time it ends.
Hold length	RULE A hard ceiling in settings (for example 24 hours, enforced by minimum/maximum). Shorter for guests (2–4 hours recommended). Never renewed silently; when time is up the piece leaves the cart.
Hoarding	RULE Caps per cart (for example 3) and per visitor across carts (for example 5, keyed by a hashed address). Note that shared Wi-Fi shares the cap.
Checkout	RULE One atomic update moves every hold from the cart to the order; if any piece fails, the order is cancelled and holds return to the cart. Double-submitting creates one claim.
Payment confirmation	RULE A per-order lock around confirmation; re-read stock and holds inside the lock. A duplicate callback changes nothing.
Late or clashing payment	RULE Money that arrives after the piece went elsewhere goes to a visible "Refund due" status with stock unchanged; staff and customer are emailed. If the piece is still free, the late payment completes the sale.
Before cancelling unpaid	RULE Ask the payment provider whether the bill was paid; settle it if so.
In-person sale	RULE Setting stock to zero removes the piece from carts, cancels a pending online order for it (with an email), and leaves any payment in progress to the late-payment rule.
Refunds and returns	RULE Refunds and cancellations of paid orders never put the piece back on sale. Staff use an explicit "return to stock" action once the piece is physically back.
Reserve and pay in store	DEFAULT A separate payment option available only with collection; stock leaves sale at once; the reservation ends after a set time and the piece returns automatically.
Scheduled work	RULE Expiry runs from a real server cron (every 5 minutes), not only on page visits. Expired holds are also cleared whenever someone tries to buy, so a late cron delays display, never correctness.
Display	RULE Status in words on cards and pages: Available, In your cart, On hold, Awaiting payment, Reserved, Sold. Sold pieces stay visible for a set period, then hide; their links keep working.
Payment wording	RULE Every mention of payment methods follows what is configured. Online payment never appears before the provider is connected.

Prove it with real parallel processes, not sequential calls: N buyers at the same instant (exactly one wins); N duplicate callbacks (one payment recorded); an in-store sale during an online checkout; late payment after expiry, with the piece free and with it held by someone else; a refund that does not relist. Use sandbox payments and test data only.

Build for where it will live

Client runs	Proven approach
Shared hosting with cPanel and WordPress	A custom theme (design and templates only) plus a companion plugin (business rules, security, staff tools, a one-click setup that fills only what is empty and skips existing pages). WooCommerce for commerce with its order tables, a payment provider's official plugin, classic cart and checkout when the theme styles them. Upload as two zip files.
A Node host with a database	A server-rendered framework with an embedded headless CMS and PostgreSQL, migrations on every deploy, S3-type file storage.

Deployment for a live WordPress site

1. Full backup, then a staging copy (host's clone or staging tool, or a subdomain). Discourage indexing on staging.
2. Install in order: commerce plugin → payment plugin → companion plugin → theme → run setup. Review pages and menus it skipped.
3. Real cron every 5 minutes and disable the visit-triggered cron.
4. Payment provider sandbox keys; one full test purchase per channel; then live keys on the live site only.
5. SMTP for email; cache rules (never cart, checkout, account; short cache for live-status pages).
6. Switch any "coming soon" mode to live at launch.

Previews for review

When the build can run as static files, share a working copy and crawl every link and image in it. When it cannot (a database-backed shop), share a labelled screenshot preview built from a local test copy (desktop and phone, including staff screens and live-status states) and a staging site for hands-on testing. Every preview says it uses test data.

Local development DEFAULT

A local copy of the real platform version (for WordPress: PHP's built-in server with a router that serves symlinked theme and plugin files, and a local database). A separate test database whose name must contain "test", which the test runner checks. A seeder for labelled test items that refuses to run on any non-local site.

Build it this way

- Semantic, server-rendered HTML first; progressive enhancement; filters and forms work without JavaScript.
- Design (theme) and business rules (plugin or service) are separate. Templates never decide whether something can be sold.
- Tokens in one file with contrast notes; one component or template per block; schema changes are additive and versioned.
- Override the platform's templates only where the design needs it, and keep its hooks so extensions still work.
- Content and contact details come from the editor; nothing factual is hard-coded.
- Database-enforced uniqueness for anything scarce; locks around anything paid.

```
// Hold acquisition (one row per piece)
INSERT IGNORE INTO holds (product_id, session_key, visitor_hash, expires_at) VALUES (…)
if affected_rows == 0: winner = SELECT … WHERE product_id = ?   // tell the shopper who holds it and until when

// Payment confirmation
GET_LOCK('order_' + id)
  if order already paid: ignore (duplicate)
  re-read stock and other holds → conflict ? status = 'refund-due' : complete sale
RELEASE_LOCK('order_' + id)

// Sideways chapter (Expressive)
inner = viewport.clientWidth - paddingLeft - paddingRight
D = max(0, track.scrollWidth - inner); pinned = largeEnough && !reducedMotion && D > 0
outer.height = 100vh + D; p = clamp((scrollY - outerTop) / D, 0, 1); track.x = -D * p
```

From brief to launch

Phase	Output
1. Analyse	Read every input; list facts, gaps and conflicts; confirm platform and hosting; ask only what changes the build.
2. Research	Two or three references reduced to written principles; an avoid list for this brand.
3. Architecture	Content model, routes, roles, business rules (stock, payments, holds), motion table, written before building.
4. System	Tokens with contrast ratios, type, layout, interaction language.
5. Build	Business layer with its tests first, then templates, forms, search, SEO, 404.
6. Content	Real content from sources; sources register; placeholders labelled.
7. Prove	The chapter 19 checklist on the real platform version; fix what it finds, including screenshot review of every key screen at desktop and phone.
8. Show	A preview the owner can open, an editor guide, and an honest report.
9. Review rounds	Treat each round as rules; fix causes; re-run the checklist; republish to the same link.
10. Launch	Staging, sandbox payment, email, cron, cache, backups, approvals of facts and photos, staff accounts.

Agent safety rules. Use sandbox payments and test data only; never charge real money or change live customer orders. Do not deploy to production or run destructive database changes without explicit approval. Never fabricate completed tests, security guarantees or performance results. Never request or paste credentials. Do not touch the client's live site from a build session. Commit to a branch; open a pull request only when asked.

Final report format. (1) Problems found. (2) Changes and why. (3) What was learned from references. (4) Tests and results, with counts. (5) Performance and accessibility work. (6) Remaining risks and what was not verified. (7) Credentials, infrastructure and manual steps the client must do.

Done means proven

Check	Evidence
Static analysis	Lint and syntax checks clean on every file.
Business rules	Tests inside the real platform (not mocks) for holds, checkout, payment confirmation, late payment, refunds, reservations, expiry, caps.
Concurrency	Parallel processes: N buyers → exactly one winner; N duplicate callbacks → one payment.
Security	Lockout, user-list privacy, form spam controls, upload limits, output escaping, headers.
End-to-end	Browse, filter, add, hold seen from a second browser (including forcing the add URL), checkout, cancel, enquiry, sign-in, staff screens, phone menu.
Accessibility	Axe WCAG 2.2 AA: zero serious or critical issues on representative pages, including cart, checkout and account. Every colour pair computed.
Overflow	No horizontal scroll at 320, 390, 768 and every listed width.
Links and images	Every internal link and image resolves on the exact preview being shared.
Claims match settings	Payment, delivery and hold wording matches what is configured, in both states (provider on and off).
Visual review	Screenshots of every key screen at desktop and phone, read by a person (or a model) before sharing; tests do not catch invisible text or overlapping controls.
Reduced motion	Every scene readable and usable.
Real devices	iOS Safari, Android Chrome, the owner's viewer. CHECK
Real host	Staging on the client's hosting with their other plugins and cache. CHECK
Payments	One full sandbox purchase per channel. CHECK
Disclosure	Unfinished items, placeholders, unverified facts and untested areas listed.

Give an AI this

A. Build a site

```
Build a professional website and content editor for [CLIENT] using the attached facts, brand assets,
information architecture and reference notes. Follow the attached Master Website Brief v2.0; my own
words override it. Never invent facts: label anything unconfirmed and keep a sources register.

Before architecture, confirm: the current live site and CMS, the hosting and control panel, who
maintains it, what is sold and how it is paid for and collected. Do not ask for credentials.

Direction: [Expressive | Quiet]. Make the subject understandable before it is spectacular. Use the
client's real photographs and brand colours by role, with one accent reserved for action. Extract
principles from [REFERENCES]; do not copy them. Avoid machine-made patterns (chapter 06).

If anything is sold: follow chapter 15 so nothing can sell twice, and prove it with parallel tests.

Safety: sandbox payments and test data only; no production deploys or destructive database changes
without my approval; never fabricate test results; work on a branch, no pull request unless I ask.

Deliver: tokens with contrast ratios, component map, motion table, editor, editor guide, sources
register, deployment guide for my hosting, a preview I can open, evidence for every check in
chapter 19, and the seven-part final report. Tell me plainly what is unfinished or unverified.
```

B. Overhaul an existing site

```
Do a production, security and design overhaul of [SITE]. Audit first and list problems with evidence.
Research [REFERENCES] and write the principles you take from each. Remove AI-generated design patterns
and build one cohesive system on the brand. Improve the editor for the people who use it daily.
If it sells anything, make double sales impossible (chapter 15). Review whether any hold or limit
enables abuse. Cover security, performance, SEO and accessibility. Test with sandbox and test data only.
Do not deploy or run destructive migrations without approval. Report in seven parts: problems,
changes and why, reference-inspired improvements, tests and results, performance and accessibility,
remaining risks, and the credentials, infrastructure and manual steps I must do.
```

Where this comes from

- **Website Design Research: Editorial clarity, spatial motion, purposeful products** (22 October 2026): five live references, the storytelling model, three motion levels, the horizontal-chapter model and access requirements.
- **Build 1**, October 2026: a 31-page school website (Next.js, Payload CMS, PostgreSQL; 25 block types), 74 automated end-to-end tests with axe scans, overflow checks at nine widths, link and image crawls; owner review rounds on 23 October 2026.
- **Build 2**, October 2026: a one-of-a-kind luxury resale shop. First built on Next.js, Payload and PostgreSQL, then rebuilt as a WordPress theme and companion plugin with WooCommerce (WordPress 7.1.3, WooCommerce 11.2.1, PHP 8.3, MariaDB 10.11) when the client's cPanel hosting was confirmed. Evidence: 19 platform tests (including 20 parallel buyers and 6 parallel duplicate callbacks) and 21 browser tests (axe WCAG 2.2 AA on 12 pages, overflow at 320/390/768px, link and image crawl, holds across two browsers, reservation checkout, enquiries, staff screens), all passing on a local copy. Reference study: Linear and Aesop, reduced to principles.
- **Owner instructions** from both builds: the rules in chapter 04.

Limits. Build 2 was not run against a real payment provider (sandbox or live), on the client's own server, on physical phones, or with screen readers; those remain launch checks. Build 1's device-specific problems were fixed by removing likely causes, not reproduced in automation. Reference sites were studied from rendered behaviour, not their code. Every value here is a proven starting point: tune it to each brand and re-test.

Version 2.0 updates and supersedes version 1.0 (23 October 2026). Typefaces in this document: Newsreader and Instrument Sans (SIL Open Font License). Reference images: Website Design Research, 22 October 2026. Build images: example implementations, 23 and 27 October 2026; build 2 images show test placeholders, not real stock.